Chapter 2: His Family and early life

1 Yunus Khān (AD 1416–1487 AD), was the Khān of Mughalistan. He reigned from AD 1462 until his death in AD 1487. Many historians claim him to be Ḥājjī `Ali of the contemporary Chinese records (Association for Asian Studies. Ming Biographical History Project Committee, 1976) (Rossabi, 2014). He was the maternal grandfather of Babur. Yunus Khān was a direct male-line descendant of Genghis Khān, through his son Chagatai Khān.

He was the eldest son of Vais Khān of Mughalistan who was assassinated in AD 1428. The issue of his succession had left Mughals split. Going against the tradition, majority of court favoured Yunus' younger brother, Esen Buqa to succeed (Association for Asian Studies. Ming Biographical History Project Committee, 1976 pp. 479-81). Looking at the prevailing situation, Yunus along with his supporters fled to Ulugh Beg, the Timurid ruler of Transoxiana. Against their hopes, they were imprisoned by Beg. But Beg's father, Shah Rukh appeared to be sympathetic to the young Yunus. Yunus received warm treatment. Shah Rukh sent Yunus to Yazd in Iran to get educated under Maulana Sharaf ad-Din Ali Yazdi. Yunus Khān spent studied under the Maulana in Yazd for quite a long time. He ends up becoming one of the most educated Mughals of his time. With the death of Maulana, Yunus felt dejected. He wandered around for some time but finally choses to settle down in the city of Shiraz in Iran.

According to a religious dignitary to Muhammad-Haydar Mīrzā Dughlat:

> *I had heard that Yunus Khān was a Mughal, and I concluded that he was a beardless man, with the ways and manners of any other Turk of the desert. But when I saw him, I found he was a person of elegant deportment, with a full beard and a Tajik face, and such refined speech and manner, as is seldom to be found even in a Tajik.*

Time was passing quite smoothly for Yunus. He was already forty by then and things seemed to be changing its flow. In AD 1456, Abu Sa'id, the Timurid ruler of Transoxiana, sent for Yunus Khān. Yunus' brother Esen Buqa was frequently raiding Sa'id's territory, and this left him badly annoyed. Esen's raid had become a nuisance. Perhaps Abu Sa'id was aware about the friction amid Yunus and Esen. He was certain that Yunus would look at this as a comeback opportunity. Yunus had both a claim on his brother's throne and kinship ties within the community. Abu Sa'id therefore raised Yunus to *Khānship* by placing him at the head of an army. He was sent to Mughalistan